CRITICAL WRITING AND READING IN ARTS · HUBEI UNIVERSITY

A soft space for every *real feeling*.

I draw picture books for children. I don't tell them what is right or wrong — I put small signs in the pictures, so the feelings they can't name yet become something they can see.

FINAL EXAM · PART 2 CLASS 16 STUDENT ID 069 ART & DESIGN, 2023–2027



《我，哭了没关系》 2026

01

PART 1 OF 3

Introduce yourself as an artist

ARTIST STATEMENT

ORIGINAL · 964 CHARACTERS · 2026

I draw picture books for children. I don't tell kids what is right or wrong. I put small signs in my pictures—a shadow, a colour that shifts—so feelings they can't name yet become something they can see.

Most of my pages start in Procreate and Photoshop. I keep my characters soft and my colours quiet. Storyboards, page layout, the look on a face — these carry the comfort. A drooping shoulder or a toy half-hidden behind a chair often shows worry better than words. I turn children's vague feelings into faces, bodies and small details, so readers feel them straight from the picture.

My work sits within children's emotional education. When kids look at my pictures, I want them to find their own feelings there. I don't tell them what to think. I just invite them to notice the messy ones, the mixed ones, and to let those feelings be. I try to create a gentle space where being small and scared isn't something you need to fix; it is okay just to sit with it.

FROM MY ART MANIFESTO

Five commandments I draw by

I Say no to moral lectures. Let conflict, weakness and imperfection exist in art.

II Use visuals to show feelings — pictures and small details, not only written words.

III Keep your true thoughts, and respect the real context.

IV Value common daily experiences; you don't need perfect characters.

V Understand what art cannot do. It can comfort, but it cannot replace real human connection.

“Art shows our inner world, but it cannot fix every problem.”

ILLUSTRATION · CHILDREN'S PICTURE BOOKS · VISUAL DEVELOPMENT · GAME & BRAND VISUAL DESIGN · AIGC PRODUCTION · PROCREATE · PS · AI · AE · C4D · BLENDER · UNITY

02

PART 2 OF 3

A short portfolio

Flip through the books themselves, then two short notes on how they were made: the character study and the research chart behind them.

FLIP THROUGH · THE BOOKS THEMSELVES

《It's Okay That I Cried》 — three volumes + the parent handbook

Vol. I 8 | Vol. II 8 | Vol. III 8 | Handbook 3



CLICK THE COVER TO OPEN

VOLUME I

COVER



It's Okay That I Cried

PARENT HANDBOOK 2026 6 PAGES · A GUIDE FOR PARENTS

A therapeutic picture book for children aged 3–6 and the adults who read with them. The protagonist is an ordinary girl, not a star: she cries when she falls, gets upset over a toy, and doesn't want to let go at the kindergarten gate. The book never says “don't cry”. It follows one feeling from the moment it appears to the moment it settles, and lets it be normal. The handbook was written for the second reader — the adult who often doesn't know what to say.

ILLUSTRATION LAYOUT WRITING



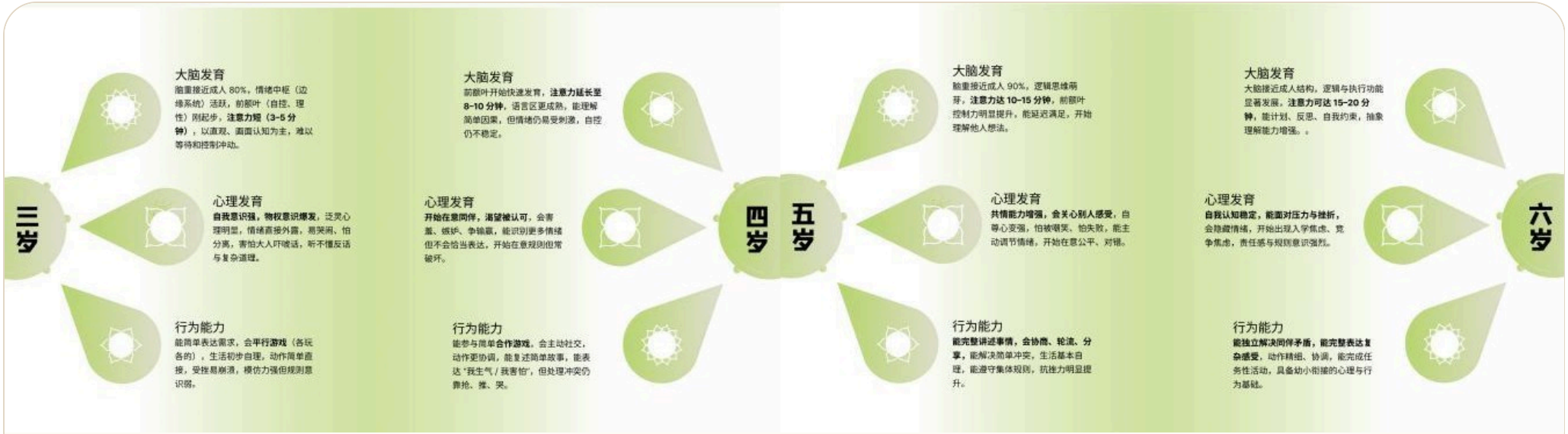
Little X, ages 3–6

CHARACTER STUDY 2026 SERIES DEVELOPMENT

One girl, four ages, one companion doll. I drew her four times so a single character could carry four different emotional ages: the doll changes size in her arms, her posture straightens, her gaze moves from the floor up to the reader. The doll is the detail that does the work — children recognise their own comfort object before they recognise themselves.

3 4 5 6

Three — the feeling arrives before the words do.



Ages 3–6: the emotional window

RESEARCH VISUALISATION 2026 FIGURE FROM MY RESEARCH PAPER

A chart I designed for my paper on art-therapy picture books. Two spreads, two age bands, three layers each: brain development, emotional cognition, behaviour. It is the argument standing behind the drawings — a picture book suits this age because the visual channel opens before the verbal one, and a feeling that cannot be said can still be seen.

INFORMATION DESIGN RESEARCH

03

PART 3 OF 3

What I actually learned

Four things from this course that changed how I look at my own work — and two things you can play with below.

01

Media is not neutral

Digital media theory taught me that software settings, platform rules and algorithms decide part of what we see. I no longer assume my default brushes, or the style that happens to be trending, are simply "how it looks". If I follow an algorithm's taste without asking, I am not making a choice — I am inheriting one.

02

The audience is a participant

In Web 1.0 people could only read; in Web 2.0 they comment, share and make their own version. So a piece of visual work is not finished when I export it — it gets finished by the people who respond to it. I design for the response now, not only for the screenshot.

03

Be honest with images

Photo editing and AIGC can produce a beautiful picture of something that never happened. That is exactly why the rule stays simple: I cannot fool people with false material. The work can be soft, quiet and emotional — but it cannot be a lie.

INTERACTIVE · RHETORIC

Three pillars, three jobs in design

Rhetoric turned out to be the most practical theory I met this term. Aristotle's Ethos, Pathos and Logos are not only for speeches — each one maps onto a different layer of the things I build.

Pathos

EMOTION

What the audience already feels.

Logos

REASON

The rules and the feedback loop.

Ethos

CREDIBILITY

The consistency of a world.

IN MY WORK

Understanding the taste of the audience, and letting the image reach it. In a game UI it is the colour, the weight, the pause before the reward. In a picture book it is the low saturation and the small, quiet detail — the feeling is persuaded, never told.

INTERACTIVE · ART CRITICISM

Where does criticism sit?

Drag the marker — or pick a name. My answer never settles at either end.

MY POSITION



Subjective taste	Diderot 18th c.	**Baudelaire & Zola 19th c.**	Greenberg 20th c.	Objective evidence

BAUDELAIRE & ZOLA, 19TH CENTURY

Baudelaire and Zola took sides for the Impressionists before the academy did. Clear positions, not neutrality — criticism as advocacy. It is not objective, and it still changed what counted as art.

Good criticism includes the feeling the work produced in me — then puts that feeling on a ground of art history, formal analysis, social context and theory. Subjectivity gives criticism its energy. Objectivity gives it something to argue with.

INTERACTIVE · BEFORE / AFTER

~~I judged a piece by whether it looked good.~~	→	Now I ask about its technical background, its user experience, and the social message it carries.
~~I thought the picture was the whole work.~~	→	Now I see the networks, the software, the platform rules and the people interacting with it.
~~I thought AI only made production faster.~~	→	Now I ask how the whole visual system guides the audience — and whether it fits the story and the goal.

AND THAT IS THE WHOLE ARGUMENT

Let art see every real human feeling.

ZHENG KAIYU

STUDENT ID 069 · ART & DESIGN, HUBEI UNIVERSITY

CRITICAL WRITING AND READING IN ARTS · CLASS 16 · FINAL EXAM, PART 2

© 2026 ZHENG KAIYU

COURSE: CAMILO ANDRÉS ROJO ORTIZ · HUBEI UNIVERSITY

BACK TO TOP ↑